Bedtime Science Story Machine

1.
Pip the fox loved the moment just before a catch — when the glowing ball hung still in the air, heavy and warm as a biscuit fresh from the oven.

Up here above the clouds, that happened a lot. She'd toss. The ball would pause. Then her friend Nimbus would snag it with a happy *poof* of gray-white fluff.

2.
But today, Nimbus looked wrong. Smaller. His sparkly eyes drooped. The little raindrops that usually danced around him were gone.

"I don't have enough water left," Nimbus said quietly. "I used it all up."

Pip landed beside him. She pressed her paw gently to his side. He felt thin, like a damp sock wrung out twice.

3.
"Where does your water *come* from?" Pip asked.

Nimbus pointed down, through a gap in the clouds. Far below, a lake glittered in the sun.

"The sun warms the water," Nimbus said slowly, remembering. "It lifts up, invisible, like a secret breath. It rises until it gets cold — and cold air squeezes it back into drops. Into *me.*"

Pip watched. A shimmer rose from the lake — she couldn't quite see it, but she felt it. Warm and damp against her nose.

Slowly, Nimbus plumped up. One drop appeared. Then another.

"It's coming," he whispered.

And when he was full and round again, a soft rain fell on the meadow below.

4.
Nimbus held up the glowing ball. Pip caught it with a thwump, wings flaring.

They played until the sun went orange and the air smelled like wet grass far below.